

MANDAR DEODHAR

Q. What about the alleged violence by protesters at Jantar Mantar?
Outsiders had infiltrated the protest. Officers and constables from the Delhi Police who sympathised with our cause told us that this was being done to serve as a justification for a crackdown. On July 19, a truck loaded with stones was parked, along with a broken-down van, by Delhi Police to serve as evidence of stone pelting by CJP supporters. The police claimed that 2,100 criminals were at Jantar Mantar. We were frisked while entering; why wasn't this done for them? This was pre-planned.

Q. How do you see Sonam Wangchuk's move to withdraw his fast?
We always told Sonam Sir to break his fast while we continued with our agitation. We were happy and relieved when he broke his fast. He was almost kidnapped from Jantar Mantar. Our team was not allowed to meet him. We couldn't communicate with him.

Q. What education reforms does the CJP want to introduce?
Primary schooling must improve. In the last decade, around 94,000 government-run schools have shut down, which means this was meant to benefit private schools. In the US, I did not see a single coaching class. Here, a nexus between the coaching industry and private schools/ colleges is obvious.

Q. What do you think about the Union government's Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026?
We are not satisfied. The focus is on what is to be done after a paper leak, which means the government takes a leak for granted. The focus must be on preventing it. Our demand for Rs 1 crore compensation for the kin of students who have died by suicide stands. The government says it will have to check rules before announcing it. The same regime cocks a snook at rules when it pays MPs/ MLAs crores for destabilising governments. We will agitate again if this is not met.

Q. What's the biggest takeaway from the CJP protest?
The biggest, most significant, achievement was that repressed voices overcame their fear and found the courage to express themselves and started questioning the central government. ■

The government was in its own bubble, thinking it could manage it. They were just being arrogant."

SO, WHO BENEFITS?

Meanwhile, one question that has arisen is who eventually benefits from the CJP's emergence. Deshmukh argues that this may prove just as important as what the CJP itself becomes. He refers to the Anna movement which ultimately benefited AAP in Delhi—and the BJP nationally. All political systems eventually tend to find someone to embody the grievance of the people, he says. "Take, for instance, Prashant Kishor's Jan Suraaj Party being dismissed mere months ago and now suddenly propelled to victory, or actor Vijay in Tamil Nadu representing the aspirations of the youth."

THE CJP'S ONLINE FOLLOWING IS PRAISED FOR ITS 'DURABILITY', BUT THE CREDIT IN PART IS DUE TO THE ORGANISED LEFT STUDENT GROUPS

Rahul Varma of the think-tank Centre for Policy Research, though, notes one significant difference as compared to the Anna movement. IAC was built on an existing ecosystem, comprising NGOs and activists, he says. "Medha Patkar, Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia, they all had their own organisations. CJP just had an Instagram page."

Just as well then that fighting elections is not on the agenda yet. "If the people say so, we will have to consider it," Dipke says. "But we have no such plans as of now." One has heard this line before. AAP chief Kejriwal, a one-time role model for Dipke, had no plans to join politics either. Watch this space to see whether the 'pressure group' stays that way, or takes the plunge. ■